XV—Bad Blood

> ‘The Lord of the world . . . was searching for some individual among the sons of men that he might hold fitting converse with . . . Though he made much search, he did not find anyone. The evangelists of the inner world, and the informants of the external, all announced that a person who could hold converse with the cream of existences must be born from himself, and that he should be urgent in begging a son from God.’
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> – Abul Fazl, prefatory remarks to the birth of Salim, *Akbarnama*

In 1600, Banarasidas was fourteen years old, living in Jaunpur, and falling in love with all the ‘yearning of a Sufi fakir’ – stealing gemstone dust from his father’s jewellery business to buy his beloved ‘paan and sweetmeats’.[1] The young Jain was very far, it might seem, from the turmoil of empire. Little did he know that the unravelling of Akbar’s family was to reach his very door.

It was in 1600 that Akbar went to the Deccan himself, and Salim took advantage of his father’s absence to run away to Allahabad and declare himself ‘shah’. The last of the rebellions against Akbar was to be led by his own son.

Now, barely 100 kilometres east of Allahabad, the governor of Jaunpur, Nuram Khan, had received an imperial farman. Salim planned to go hunting near Jaunpur and Nuram Khan was not to allow it on any account. Hunting was as often a euphemism for war as Mecca was for exile, a show of force meant to intimidate. Nuram Khan prepared for battle and siege.

‘All roads leading to and from Jaunpur were blocked,’ Banarasidas recalls. ‘Boats were no longer allowed to stop at the ghats along the Gomti / All bridges and gateways into the city were closed.’ There were guards everywhere, ‘And artillery set up on the walls and ramparts of the city’; Nuram Khan stockpiled provisions of every kind: grain, clothing, water, armour, saddles, guns, and, of course, ‘Much wine, and many kinds of weapons’.

As the city filled up with soldiers and their armaments, it emptied of residents, who ‘ran away in all directions’. Banarasidas’s father was part of a delegation of jewellers who went to Nuram Khan, asking if they, too, should leave. Nuram Khan had little solace for them. ‘Listen O merchants,’